

SOP-LV-035 — Confined Space Awareness

Recognizing a Confined Space Before You Enter — and When to Stop

SOP NUMBER	SOP-LV-035
TITLE	Confined Space Awareness
EFFECTIVE DATE	July 25, 2026
REVISION	1.0
APPLIES TO	All Apex field technicians — Ontario & Manitoba
CATEGORY	Environmental Hazards

1. Purpose

This procedure helps Apex technicians recognize a confined space before entering it. Apex technicians do not perform permit-required confined space entry — this SOP is about awareness and escalation, not entry procedure.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all Apex technicians who may encounter a confined space — crawl spaces, mechanical or electrical vaults, and some restricted-access ceiling plenums — in the course of cabling or security work.

3. Definitions

- Confined Space — a space that is not designed for continuous human occupancy, has limited or restricted means of entry and exit, and may accumulate a hazardous atmosphere.
- Permit-Required Confined Space — a confined space that additionally has the potential for a serious atmospheric or engulfment hazard, requiring specialized entry procedures, testing, and standby personnel.

4. Apex's Position on Confined Space Entry

Apex technicians do not perform permit-required confined space entry.

If a task appears to require entering a permit space, stop and escalate to your supervisor. Apex will arrange a qualified contractor if entry is genuinely required for the job.

5. Recognizing a Confined Space Before Entry

- Limited entry or exit points — a hatch, small opening, or single restricted path in and out.
- Poor or no ventilation.
- Potential for oxygen deficiency or accumulation of hazardous gas.
- Not designed or intended for continuous human occupancy.

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6. Common Examples on Apex Jobsites

- Crawl spaces under portable classrooms or additions.
- Mechanical or electrical vaults with restricted access.
- Some ceiling plenum spaces with limited access points, depending on layout.

Most standard drop-ceiling and attic work is not a confined space — the distinction is restricted entry/exit and the potential for a hazardous atmosphere, not simply being enclosed or hard to reach.

7. When Uncertain

If you are not sure whether a space qualifies as confined, treat it as one and escalate to your supervisor before entering — the same stop-and-confirm standard Apex applies to unmarked utilities and uncertain anchor points elsewhere in this SOP series.

8. Atmospheric Hazard Awareness

Never enter a space that smells unusual, shows signs of mold or gas, or where a gas detector (if provided) alarms. Back out immediately and report it.

9. Emergency Response

Never attempt to rescue someone collapsed in a confined space yourself.

More people are injured or killed attempting an untrained rescue than from the original incident — the same hazard that affected them will affect you. Call 911 immediately; confined space rescue requires specialized training and equipment.

10. Reporting

Report any confined space encountered on a jobsite to your supervisor, even if you did not enter it, so it can be flagged for future visits to that site.

11. Regulatory References

- Ontario O. Reg. 632/05 — Confined Spaces
- Ontario Occupational Health and Safety Act, s. 25 — general duty
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Regulation — Confined Space provisions

12. Related Apex Documents

- SOP-LV-002 — Concrete Floor Drilling & Utility Strike Prevention
- SOP-LV-029 — Lone Worker Safety

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13. Revision History

Rev.	Date	Description	Approved By
1.0	Jul 25, 2026	Initial release	P. Cimini

This document is proprietary to Apex and is intended for internal use by Apex technicians and supervisors. Effective date: July 25, 2026.